

ROMAN TOWN

In the early afternoon of August 24, 79 CE, a dark cloud of smoke, ash, and red-hot rock filled the sky above the busy Roman port of Pompeii as the volcano, Mount Vesuvius, erupted. Its ash covered the city, preserving it perfectly. The remains offer a unique insight into how the ancient Romans lived.



The Roman Empire

Pompeii lay south of Rome, the center of the Roman Empire, in the Bay of Naples. Many of the estimated 20,000 people who lived in Pompeii were full citizens of the empire.



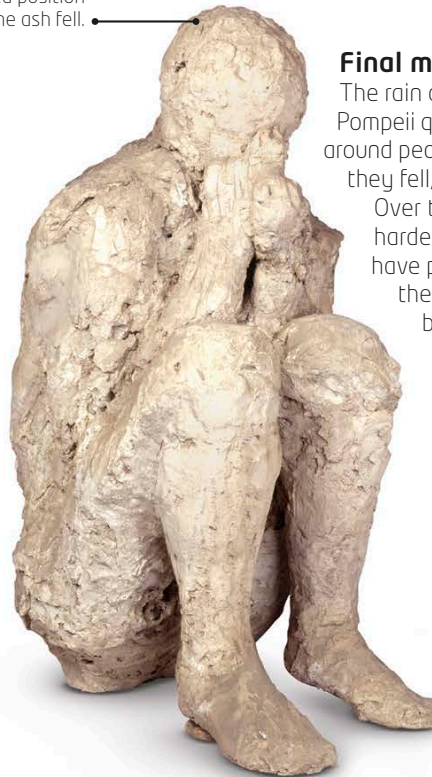
Blue jug

Ash from the eruption of Vesuvius preserved many delicate items, such as this glass jug, in very good condition.

By examining the jug, historians can tell how it was made and used.

This blue color was created by adding a mineral, cobalt oxide, to the glass.

This person huddled in a crouched position as the ash fell.



Final moments

The rain of ash that fell on Pompeii quickly set in place around people's bodies where they fell, suffocated by the ash.

Over time, the ash and debris hardened. Archaeologists have poured plaster into the cavities left by the bodies to make casts of the dead.

Tools of the trade

To excavate a site, archaeologists must work very carefully. Brushes and picks help them expose their discoveries.



Early exploration

It was always known that there was a hidden Roman city near Naples, but it wasn't until 1748 that excavations began. This photo shows archaeologists at Pompeii in the late 19th century.



Rooftop remains

The person being excavated here might have been one of the last to die in the disaster. Their body was found on the roof of a villa. They probably climbed up to try and escape the danger.

